deities throughout the year, and will also serve as a *parikrama* path for the devotees. Adjacent to this is the 14-metre-wide landscape zone, planned with local arboriculture. This garden showcases almost 200 varieties of trees—among them saptaparni, patali, baula, kadamba—that are integral to the Jagannath cult.

The outer circumambulation, or the Bahya Pradakshina, spans eight metres and is lined by trees on both sides, a serene pathway for visitors. Following this is the public convenience zone, stretching 10 metres wide, featuring nine restrooms, drinking water facilities, two information-cum-donation kiosks, three mini cloakrooms, one police kiosk, an open-air auditorium and two shelter pavilions, all surrounded by decorative plants. Then, there is a five-metre-wide service lane reserved for service vehicles and corridor maintenance, ensuring seamless functionality. Next is the 4.5-metre-wide dedicated shuttle-cum-emergency lane, a crucial area designed for swift response during emergencies. The last two zones include a 7.5-metre-wide mixed traffic lane facilitating movement, ensuring access to adjacent lanes and properties. Additionally, there is a seven-metre-wide shaded footpath.

The construction follows the Kalingan architectural style, utilising the same Khondalite rock found in the main temple. The stones were sourced from the mines of the Odisha Mining Corporation in Khordha, Jajpur, Nayagarh and other locations.

The revamp is set to address various spatial limitations and accommodate approximately 100,000 devotees expected for the Suna Besha, a crucial ritual concluding the Rath Yatra. Before the redevelopment, only a few thousand individuals could congregate. The corridor will enable more than 20,000 devotees to witness the daily ritual of changing the Patitapaban Bana, the flag atop the temple, from the amphitheatre. Also, officials believe that individuals from different faiths can have a glimpse of the temple from the *pradakshina* path and spend time in its vicinity. Only Hindus are permitted to enter the precincts of the temple itself.

As part of the ABADHA initiative, 22 projects have been planned for Puri, with the *parikrama* project being one of them. Among the additional initiatives are the Rs 200 crore Shree Setu, a 2.3-km four-lane interchange link connecting the Badadanda to the national highway; a 630-metre-long and 40-foot-wide link road called Shree Danda or Shree Marg connecting Puri bypass to Jagannath Ballav Pilgrim Centre built for Rs 278.6 crore, intended to alleviate traffic congestion in the city; and the Rs 100 crore multi-modal hub at the centre, equipped with amenities such as multi-level parking, commercial space and meditation areas.

In addition to the peripheral corridor, there are two



planned 80-metre-long shaded pathways on the Badadanda. One of these pathways, providing seating for pilgrims, has already been constructed, and the other will be completed soon. Each of these pathways can accommodate up to 2,000 people simultaneously. Furthermore, a separate air-conditioned pathway near the temple, equipped with seating for 1,500 people, has been built.

OVERCOMING HURDLES

Even if it is for a divine cause, displacement can never be an easy task. The temple project, too, encountered hurdles since the very inception, especially when it came to removing structures from the surrounding areas, comprising century-old *mathas*, private residential buildings and commercial complexes. The *mathas* were demolished amidst protests. Patnaik made an emotional appeal to those facing displacement, urging them to make sacrifices for the shrine's sake.

"Almost everyone gave up their land willingly. They have been handsomely rewarded and will be rehabilitated as well," says Samarth Verma, the former district magistrate and collector of Puri, and the current additional chief administrator of the Shree Jagannatha Temple Administration. But a bigger challenge awaited once the land acquisition was done—the matter was 'politicised', according to Verma. The opposition BJP alleged that the project violated the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (AMASR) Act, 1958. The party's MP from Bhubaneswar, Aparajita Sarangi, wrote an open letter to Patnaik in March 2021. "In the name of beautification, some of the most sacred *mathas* of Puri... have been demolished. I believe you are aware of the roles of the *mathas* in the development of the Jagannath cult and in many of the rituals associated with Lord Jagannath," the letter said.